

Nicolás Vela

Design Engineer · Principal Front-End Engineer · UI/UX Designer
React · TypeScript · Vue · Angular · Design Systems · AI-Augmented Development

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Portfolio · LinkedIn · GitHub · Design archive

Summary

Front-end engineer with 20+ years designing, building, and modernizing web platforms, and a formal graphic design background. That combination is the core of how I work: I can take an interface from visual concept and Figma prototype to a production-grade, performant React/TypeScript implementation, and I can set the architecture and standards that keep it maintainable.

I started writing HTML and CSS in the IE6 era, when cross-browser compatibility was done by hand, and I have worked through every major shift since: jQuery and Backbone, AngularJS, then React, Vue, and modern Angular. I have led teams of up to 10 people, run up to 10 simultaneous projects, and acted as the technical point of contact for enterprise clients. Since 2023 I have worked AI-augmented every day (GitHub Copilot, Claude, ChatGPT) and have built AI-integrated features with Azure AI Foundry, Airia, and RAG-based architectures.

Core Competencies

Area	Detail
Front-End Engineering	React (16–18), TypeScript, Vue.js 2 & 3, Angular (AngularJS through modern), JavaScript (ES6+), component architecture, state management, UI architecture
CSS & Visual Systems	CSS3, SCSS/Sass, Less, Stylus, Tailwind, Bootstrap, Foundation, Material UI, Ant Design, BEM, CSS-in-JS; responsive design; cross-browser compatibility (IE6+) and legacy CSS/HTML; design-to-code fidelity
Design & UX	Figma, Adobe XD, Sketch, Illustrator, Photoshop, Adobe Suite; UI/UX design, usability, wireframing and flow mapping (draw.io), visual identity, image optimization for web and print (formats, resolution, DPI)
Performance	Core Web Vitals, Google Lighthouse optimization, SEO fundamentals
Back-End & APIs	Node.js (Express, Fastify), TypeScript, .NET Core / .NET Framework (C#), PHP (Laravel, Slim), REST APIs, WebSockets / Socket.io (real-time); basic Python and Spring Boot; JWT, OWASP Top 10
Cloud & DevOps	CI/CD pipelines in GitHub Actions and Azure DevOps (YAML); Microsoft Entra ID with role-based access control; Azure Key Vault for secrets; Linux production servers (Nginx, PM2, firewall and port rules, IP allow-listing, VPN); Docker (working knowledge); Firebase; DigitalOcean
AI-Augmented Development	Daily use of GitHub Copilot, Claude, ChatGPT; Azure AI Foundry, Airia; RAG architectures; agent-driven development methodology
Leadership & Delivery	Tech lead, Project Manager, IT Director; teams of up to 10; Agile / Scrum / Kanban; client-facing technical discovery and estimation; account management
Databases	MongoDB, Firestore, SQL Server, MySQL, PostgreSQL, Oracle
CMS & Platforms	Liferay, Episerver (Optimizely), WordPress, Joomla, Drupal, Moodle, Blackboard

Professional Experience

Capmation — Principal Engineer · Front-End Architecture, UI Systems & Full-Stack

2023 – PRESENT

Technical lead for front-end work across enterprise client platforms, plus full-stack delivery and AI-augmented development.

- Architected and built front-end systems in React, Angular, and Vue for .NET, Episerver, and cloud-based applications; built and maintained back-end APIs in .NET Core and .NET Framework with Azure integrations.

- Defined front-end standards, CSS architecture, and documentation used across multiple teams, reducing technical debt and speeding up onboarding.
- Maintained and modernized legacy front-end code (.NET, Episerver) alongside modern React, Vue, and Angular implementations.
- Introduced AI-accelerated workflows with GitHub Copilot, ChatGPT, and Claude; used Azure AI Foundry and Airia for AI-driven feature development, including integration patterns aligned with RAG architectures.
- Prototyped UI components and user flows in Figma and Sketch to align design and engineering before implementation.

Selected projects at Capmation

- **AI-TimeTracker (internal AI-powered time-tracking platform).** Led the project end to end: Director, PM, designer, and developer for the first three months, then Tech Lead for the last two, while the team grew from 2 to 5. Planned and delivered with an agent-driven development methodology from kickoff to pilot in under a month; now releasing to external clients in production. Built the initial CI/CD pipelines in GitHub Actions and Azure DevOps (YAML) and maintained them; implemented authentication with Microsoft Entra ID and a four-role access model (admin, billing, manager, member) managed in Azure; used Azure Key Vault for secrets. Co-owned deployment and development with a second engineer.
- **Technical discovery with RAG tooling (whiteboard / POC).** Facilitated discovery and estimation sessions using RAG-based tools to synthesize client requirements, model delivery scenarios across timelines, and build rapid proofs of concept, producing time and cost ranges ready for negotiation.
- **Support agents with human-in-the-loop learning.** Researched and prototyped agent-based support: domain data chunked into agent knowledge bases, with escalation flows where unresolved queries are answered by humans and fed back into the knowledge base, progressively reducing escalations.
- **Regulatory Compliance Management Platform — Document Folders.** Angular 8 front end and .NET back end on Azure for a licensed cultivation-to-distribution business regulated across several states. Designed and built the reference-document module where every file is audit evidence: one nested tree for folders, files, authored content and links; jurisdiction as a filterable column instead of duplicated folders; archive-before-delete; and destructive actions gated by an explicit confirmation that lists exactly what will be removed. Prototyped every component and state in Figma before implementation.
- **Hybrid .NET E-Commerce Platform (construction materials).** Hybrid architecture combining legacy .NET Framework and modern .NET Core services; Vue.js 2 and 3 front ends; Azure infrastructure and integrations; catalog, pricing, and ordering, with an incremental modernization strategy.
- **Health & Nutrition Platform.** Translated product discovery into scalable full-stack solutions, with emphasis on back-end APIs, data modeling, and business rules.

ITZAM — Senior Developer, Technology Project Manager & React Lead

2018 – 2022

Managed a team of 8 across up to 4 simultaneous projects; front-end lead and React specialist on all major client deliveries, with TypeScript back ends on Express and Fastify. Designed business-process flow maps and turned them into UX proposals using XD, draw.io, Sketch, Illustrator, and Photoshop.

- **PAS HQ — GPS installation management platform (Mexico, 2019).** React 17 web app for materials inventory and real-time installer tracking, with a Flutter mobile companion; clean architecture and a TypeScript/Express back end.
- **Aseguradora del Sur — connected-car insurance platform (2019–2021, shipped to iOS and Android).** Led the project from three emergency buttons to a full platform: Flutter mobile app (I designed 100% of the UX/UI with the client and code-reviewed the Flutter implementation), a React 16 command center for notifications, data and customer communication, and a Node/Express + WebSockets API. Integrated the insurer's roadside-assistance provider (real-time tow and assistance tracking), its policy systems (renewals and new-product sales) and in-vehicle GPS devices (telemetry, trips and a driver score). Built the whole back end and web front end and ran the infrastructure on Linux servers.
- **Maresa — Gestor Único Comercial (2020–2021).** Lead designer and lead developer, team of 3. Mapped the dealership's sales process and modeled it as a 7-stage pipeline that drives every screen, action, email and role permission. React 16, TypeScript, Ant Design, Node, SignalR for real-time updates; owned the infrastructure on Windows Server.
- **Maresa — customer chat and video-call platform (2021).** React 16 front end and real-time communication with a TypeScript back end.
- **Banco Santander — "Hombre Vivo" emergency platform (Mexico; advanced stage, not released to production).** Employee-safety platform for high-risk environments where staff report location, status, and emergency type during an incident. React 16 and TypeScript.

PPM — Senior Full-Stack Developer

2018

Developed and administered web systems in React for Diners Club; supervised weekly Diners campaign sends by customer segment; maintained internal sales and communication tools; planned and allocated work for the design and development team.

Ariadna Communication Group — IT Director · Senior Software Developer

2015 – 2018

Full-stack developer and tech lead. Took over a team with no lead and no version control. Managed a team of up to 10 and up to 10 simultaneous projects in C#, Java, PHP, JavaScript, CSS, HTML, Node, and Sass.

- **Process and standards.** Rolled out Git and JIRA across 10+ projects; introduced Scrum and Kanban with WIP limits; made coding standards mandatory for outside contractors; wrote a training plan for the team.
- **Movistar Ecuador (2015–2018).** Directed, maintained, and developed the public website on Liferay Enterprise 6. Built fully admin-driven Angular catalogs that **cut catalog administration time by 50%**. Wrote ET-CSS, a config-driven utility-first Sass framework used across Movistar production sites, to compose banners and enforce correct application of the brand's graphic material; a Slim 2 PHP API connecting the front end to services; a token generator ("Medusa", 5-minute tokens validated via POST) to protect sensitive data; and **OBO (Order Back Office)**, a Laravel 5.2 system that receives and processes web-form and call-center orders from start to delivery and triggers automated customer calls through a SOAP integration. Front ends in Angular 1, jQuery, and Bootstrap.
- **PwC — Human Talent Recruitment System (2017).** Directed delivery in .NET Framework 4.5 (MVC, Razor, Entity Framework, SQL Server, REST, Windows Service, Windows Authentication). My team took over a project in poor condition after the previous team resigned and delivered it in six months.
- **Kia Ecuador (2016).** Direction and development of the SGC system, including a CRM that handles all customers arriving at dealers and guides sales executives through to a sale; plus several public and private systems in PHP, JavaScript, Angular 1, jQuery, and MySQL.

Hotel Quito — Creative Director & IT Development

2014 – 2015

Led a team of 2. Conceptual development of communication campaigns, graphic design and production, oversight of corporate image, development and maintenance of sales and communication tools, and planning of design and development work. Built the hotel's responsive WordPress site (Foundation framework, parallax).

Campus Virtual de Cocina — Project Manager

2014

Led a team of 4. E-learning platform development and maintenance, teaching-tool conceptualization, campaign concepts, graphic design and production, corporate image oversight.

Fourthwave — Project Manager & Developer

2010 – 2013

Led a team of 10. Managed an average of 10 active client accounts; campaign concepts, graphic design and production, IT tool development, and work planning. Front-end work for Zaimella Ecuador (interactive menu tabs and a JavaScript interactive map).

Plus-Projects — Creative Direction & Front-End Developer

2007 – 2010

Campaign concepts, digital graphic pieces, design, development, and maintenance of front-end web applications and multimedia products (including ActionScript multimedia CDs).

Earlier roles in graphic design (2006–2007)

- **Punto y Magenta Diseño** — Graphic designer (advertising and print design, digital illustration; 270-hour internship converted to a role).
- **Mediterráneo Comunicación** — Graphic designer (advertising and print, digital illustration, studio photography).

Freelance & Independent Work

Period	Client	Work
2022	Aerialoop	Drone-delivery platform across mobile, web and B2B: product design, Vue 3 front end with real-time map tracking, infrastructure on Linux servers

Period	Client	Work
2021 – 2024	Pacarina art workshop	Social media management, graphic design, web development, photography
2015 – 2016	Asociación de ahorro y crédito Andalucía	Corporate website; "Club me apunto" rewards redemption system (AngularJS, Laravel)
2014	Lexvalor	Website and multi-level user application
2014	Arte en Cumbayá	"Juguetearte" toy exhibition: digital graphics and landing page
2011	MySuit	Website design and development; virtual store with billing packages
2011	Arte en Cumbayá	Website design and development; online catalog and store
2009	MySuit	Multimedia disc: design and development
2008	MIES (Ministry of Economic and Social Inclusion)	Design, layout, and character illustration for a public guide
2008	Red Cross Blood Center	Signage design
2008	NaturSudamérica	Corporate image
2007	Ecuador Adventure	Geo MTB Rally image, website design and development
2007	Peugeot – Auto France Ecuador	Website redesign and implementation
2007	Arte en Cumbayá	Visual identity manual
2006	Mi Inmobiliaria	Website design and development

Education

- **Advertising Graphic Design Technician** — Universidad Tecnológica Equinoccial, 2006. Thesis: design and development of a visual identity manual and web design.
- **Sound Technology** (5 semesters, not completed) — Instituto de Artes Visuales Quito, 2008.
- **Bachelor of Science (high school)** — El Sauce, 2003.

Certifications & Continuous Training

Year	Credential
2026	Microsoft Azure Fundamentals (AZ-900); Azure AI Fundamentals (AI-900) in progress
2024	OutSystems Associate Reactive Developer
2020	Docker (Platzi); GitLab DevOps (Platzi)
2017	Agile and Scrum Methodologies (Platzi)
2015	JavaScript Fundamentals; JavaScript and jQuery (Platzi)
2014	PHP Laravel (Platzi)

Languages

- **Spanish** — native
- **English** — reading B2, writing B2, speaking B1–B2

Additional

Interests: web and e-learning, design, music and sound production, environmental management, culture. References available on request.